

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 346

Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1952-1953

Coverage Date: Ca. 1950s

Place Coverage: !Kung San, Nyae Nyae Region, Namibia

Section Title(S): Polygynous Marriages

The number of wives a man may have is not regulated by social rules but by his ability to obtain and support them. This limits him usually to one. None of the nine polygynists in the band had more than two. However, we heard of a man named Gao, now dead, who had had four wives all at one time. He had been a fabulous hunter and maker of arrows and was the father of the /Ti/kay who is the husband of two sisters, /Naoka and !Nai, in Band 9.

595
Polygamy

Only two of the nine pairs of co-wives had traceable consanguineous relationship. The above /Ti!kay's wives were sisters—the only ones—and, in Band 10, Old #Gao's younger wife, !Ghia, was the BrDa of his older wife, Bau.

595
Polygamy

!Kwi, sister, is the term which co-wives apply to each other, unless they have the same name, in which case they term each other *!gu!na*. The !Kung, though they do not institutionalize the sororate, say it is a good idea to marry sisters because they are not so likely to be jealous of each other as other women. /Ti!kay's wives, who appeared to live in harmony and affection and to support each other, provided an example of the validity of this opinion.

595
Polygamy

601
Kinship Terminology

Marriage to the same man gives co-wives the joking relationship, and they do not observe the sitting or the name avoidance, though they may have avoided each other before marriage.

595
Polygamy

!Kung co-wives share one scherm and one family fire. The scherm, the little shelter of branches and grass which the women build, a half hemisphere in shape, is only 3 to 4 ft. wide on the open side, about 3 ft. deep at the centre, perhaps 4 to 5 ft. high at the peak. In it and in front of it, beside their one fire, the two wives live, share their man, share the food they gather, share the work of fetching water and wood, nurse each other's babies, and co-operate in whatever degree of harmony their spirits can attain.

342
Dwellings

595
Polygamy

Husbands and wives may sleep separately or lie close together, side by side, or feet to feet. The woman holds her infant in her arms. Young children sleep near by bundled together, two or three in one kaross. Girls at about seven or eight go to sleep with a grandmother or a widowed friend or relative. The boys of the band, beginning at the same age, all sleep at a boys' fire.

513
Sleeping

/Ti!kay (Band 9), husband of the two attractive sisters, sees to it that his wives lie close to him, especially on cold nights, one on each side. Sleeping thus they were like the three stars of Orion which we call the Belt, but which the !Kung say are three zebras, two females with a male between them.

513
Sleeping

595
Polygamy

821
Ethnometeorology

It is under such conditions that the !Kung usually have sexual intercourse—at night, in their sleeping place. They cover themselves with their karosses and are very discreet. The position is to lie on the side, the man at the back of the woman. Men pull the labia of the women before intercourse. The wives of /Ti!kay told me that they took pleasure in intercourse. I asked them if they had orgasms. We had  347 considerable difficulty with the interpretation, but I believe they finally understood what I was trying to say. They did, they said, and added that one sleeps very well afterwards.

513
Sleeping

833
Sexual Intercourse

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)